

Who You Refer To

Your most expensive question in the entire exam is here — missed seven times. Every question in this lesson picks a specialist.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 7 TIMES

There is a crack at the upper corner of a wall on the lock side of an interior door. The crack gets wider as it runs toward the ceiling. The door rubs against the lock side jamb. What is the best recommendation?

Evaluation by a contractor.

Seven times. This is the most expensive single question you own, so it is worth slowing down on. The symptoms describe real movement: a crack that widens as it rises, and a door binding on the lock side, mean the opening is no longer square. Something is moving.

So why a contractor rather than an engineer? Because your job is to recognize that something beyond your scope is happening and hand it to someone who can open it up and find out. The contractor investigates and repairs. An engineer is for designing a fix once the cause is established. Recommending evaluation is the inspector's move — you are not diagnosing, you are escalating.

The rest of the referral list

Service drop through tree branches	An arborist should evaluate the tree. The tree is the problem, so the tree specialist gets the referral — not an electrician.
Radon contamination	Correcting it should be conducted by a radon mitigation contractor.
Well pump not working	Advise the client and suggest they hire a well professional.
Suspected mold	Handled by noting it and referring the buyer to a qualified person. You do not identify mold by eye.
Suspected asbestos	Mention that it may be asbestos and recommend testing. Note the hedge — "may be" — because you cannot confirm it without a laboratory.

The pattern across all of these is the same: name what you observed, say what it might mean, and hand it to the right specialist. You never confirm, never diagnose and never repair. When a question offers you an answer that commits to a cause, that is usually the wrong one.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. Widening crack toward the ceiling, door rubbing the lock-side jamb. Recommendation?
2. Why a contractor rather than a structural engineer?
3. Service drop running through tree branches — who evaluates?
4. Who corrects radon, and who deals with a dead well pump?
5. How do you handle suspected mold, and suspected asbestos?
6. State the general pattern in one sentence.